

Colombia's 2026 Elections: Implications for U.S. Relations

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On August 7, 2026, right-wing political outsider and former criminal defense lawyer Abelardo de la Espriella was inaugurated to a four-year presidential term, succeeding Gustavo Petro of the Historic Pact (PH), Colombia's first left-wing president. De la Espriella [narrowly defeated](#) PH senator Iván Cepeda, 49.7% to 48.7%, in a June runoff. President Trump [endorsed](#) de la Espriella, who has vowed to [restore](#) a "close relationship" with the [United States](#) after some strains under Petro.

Since the late 1990s, Congress has [sought to foster](#) closer security and economic ties with Colombia, including by appropriating extensive U.S. foreign assistance for the country. The 119th Congress reduced foreign assistance to Colombia and placed additional conditions on the remaining assistance, however, due to concerns about the Petro government's [security policies](#). De la Espriella supports a military-led security policy and has joined U.S.-backed regional security efforts. Some Members of Congress have [pledged](#) to strengthen ties and offered "[full support](#)" to de la Espriella. Others support continued cooperation while [urging](#) the new government to adopt a more holistic approach to security by implementing the [2016 peace accord](#) intended to end Colombia's internal armed conflict.

2026 Elections

President Petro's legacy influenced Colombia's 2026 elections. Supporters praised Petro's focus on reducing inequality through labor reform and minimum wage increases. Critics noted that the Petro administration's de-emphasis of coca eradication [coincided](#) with record cocaine production. The government's "[total peace](#)" negotiations involving ceasefires with illegally armed groups arguably [bolstered](#) such groups' power as their use of [drones](#) and involvement in [illegal mining](#) proliferated. Crime and corruption were among voters' [top concerns](#) in the election, which was marred by [political violence](#), including the [assassination](#) of a presidential hopeful.

Legislative Elections

Colombia's March 8 legislative election results illustrated a left-right division among voters amid continued fragmentation in the party system. PH captured the most Senate (25 of 103) and House of Representatives (43 of 183) seats, and the conservative Democratic Center (CD) garnered the second-largest number of seats in both chambers (17 and 28, respectively). Parties that collectively control 61%

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of the Senate and 67% of the House [joined](#) President de la Escriella's governing coalition, but maintaining their support may prove challenging.

Presidential Contest

Colombia began its presidential contest with hundreds of candidates, but the field narrowed to three major candidates. Cepeda led the polls from January until the first-round election on May 31. De la Escriella used [social media](#), rallies, and support from evangelical churches to consolidate conservative support and surpass Paloma Valencia of the CD. He [won](#) 44% of the first-round vote, finishing ahead of Cepeda (41%) and Valencia (6%), and then [defeated](#) Cepeda in the runoff. After a recount, Cepeda conceded while Petro [claimed](#) fraud occurred, contradicting [international observers](#). De la Escriella's narrow margin of victory reflected Colombia's political polarization.

New Government: Goals and Challenges

Analysts have variously described President de la Escriella as a “[maverick](#)” who lacks strong ideological leanings but wants to concentrate power in the executive and as a [pragmatist](#) who will only implement right-wing policies if they are popular. De la Escriella [vowed](#) to establish a country that is safe and prosperous, investor-friendly but fiscally austere, and protective of conservative social values. He has ended Petro's dialogues with armed groups, expanded extraditions, and deployed the military to combat illegally armed groups. His government reopened the hydrocarbons sector to private investment and increased the 2027 budget proposal to support recovery from an August 10 earthquake, which may cost some [\\$10 billion](#).

The government inherited [growing](#) debt and a deteriorating security situation, and several factors may hinder its ability to respond to those challenges. In July, de la Escriella [suspended](#) the presidential transition process after Petro refused to recognize his victory. Consequently, his Cabinet may not have [received](#) full information from outgoing officials. In July, the PH and CD united to defeat de la Escriella's preferred candidate for Senate president, foreshadowing possible legislative pushback despite de la Escriella's working majorities. In September, a court [paused](#) a pilot project to restart aerial coca fumigation.

Implications for U.S. Policy

President de la Escriella, who also holds U.S. and Italian citizenship, has vowed to revitalize U.S.-Colombia relations. He has joined President Trump's [Americas Counter Cartel Coalition](#) and [Shield of the Americas](#) regional security and diplomatic initiatives and offered to host joint operations targeting illegally armed groups. Some analysts [argue](#) his policy toward Venezuela is likely to be influenced by the Trump Administration's approach.

On August 7, the Trump Administration [announced](#) it would work with Congress to provide \$1 billion in support to help the de la Escriella administration combat narco-terrorism and advance economic opportunity. The State Department has provided some [\\$26.5 million](#) in earthquake assistance and reportedly [reprogrammed](#) a portion of \$52 million in foreign military financing from other countries to Colombia. The Administration requested at least \$87 million for Colombia in its [FY2027 budget proposal](#); the Administration has not publicly released foreign aid allocations for Colombia since FY2024.

On September 8, Secretary Marco Rubio visited Colombia and [said](#) he hoped to start a “new cooperation stage” in bilateral relations. Secretary Rubio signed memorandums of understanding with the Colombian government on civilian nuclear cooperation and critical minerals development. He did not announce any new security assistance for Colombia or a [reduction](#) in U.S. tariffs on Colombian goods. Secretary Rubio [said](#) the United States is “willing to do everything necessary” in compliance with Colombian law to carry

out joint military operations. Such operations could [require](#) Colombian Senate approval. On September 16, President Trump [maintained](#) Colombia on the list of countries that “failed demonstrably” to meet their international counternarcotics obligations but found that the continued provision of U.S. assistance to Colombia is in the U.S. national interest.

Congress may track developments in U.S.-Colombia relations as it considers appropriations and other legislation. Congress could adjust the level, type, or conditions on foreign assistance for Colombia in FY2027 National Security, Department of State, and Related Programs Appropriations legislation.

Congress could also authorize, prohibit, or condition U.S. military involvement in Colombia.

Additionally, Congress could assess how U.S. tariffs have affected bilateral trade and consider measures to codify, terminate, or adjust the tariffs.

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